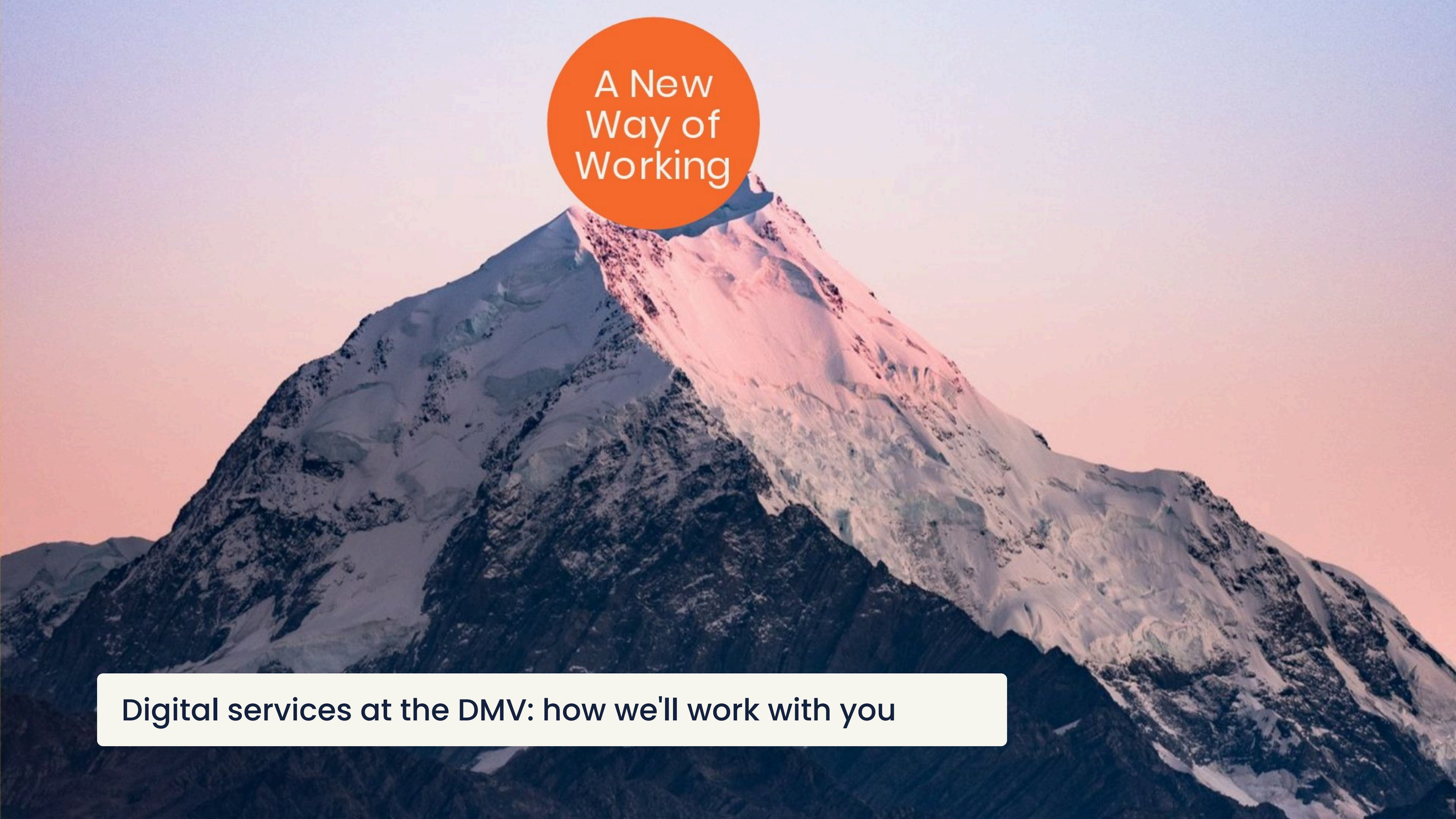


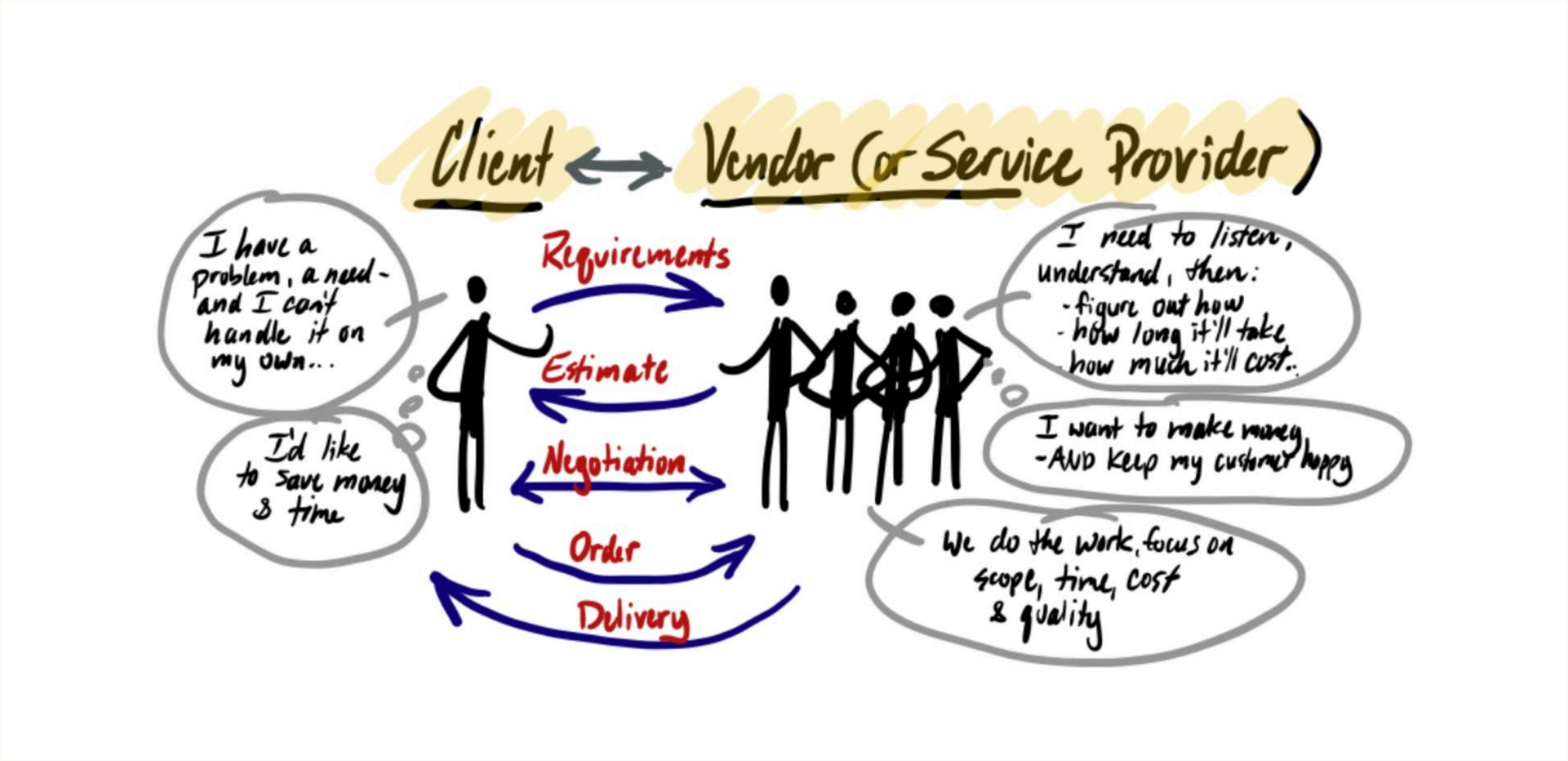

# Digital services at the DMV: how we'll work with you

# Our current state of IT

- ⚠ Lots of work that takes a long time to get to
- ✓ **A big team full of committed individuals**
- ⚠ A frustrated user base that can't get what they need to make their jobs easier
- ⚠ Big projects that don't succeed
- ⚠ A friction between the business and the technology teams

How do we evolve to meet the needs of our community and our partners?

We need to switch from a focus on **output** to a focus on **outcome and impact**




The client-vendor relationship most IT organizations use today



# When client-vendor works

### Works well

1. "Fixed" output, like hardware
2. A single client
3. Clear requirements
4. Only the client is affected

### Doesn't work well

1. Output that keeps changing
2. Many clients
3. Unknown requirements
4. Client and users both affected



So how do we switch to an **outcome** focused way of working?

# Digital Services

a new working model

# 4 core tenets

of digital services



User-centric



Measurable impact



Empowered teams



Collaborative partners




# User-centric

Putting the human being at the center of all work

### Increase success

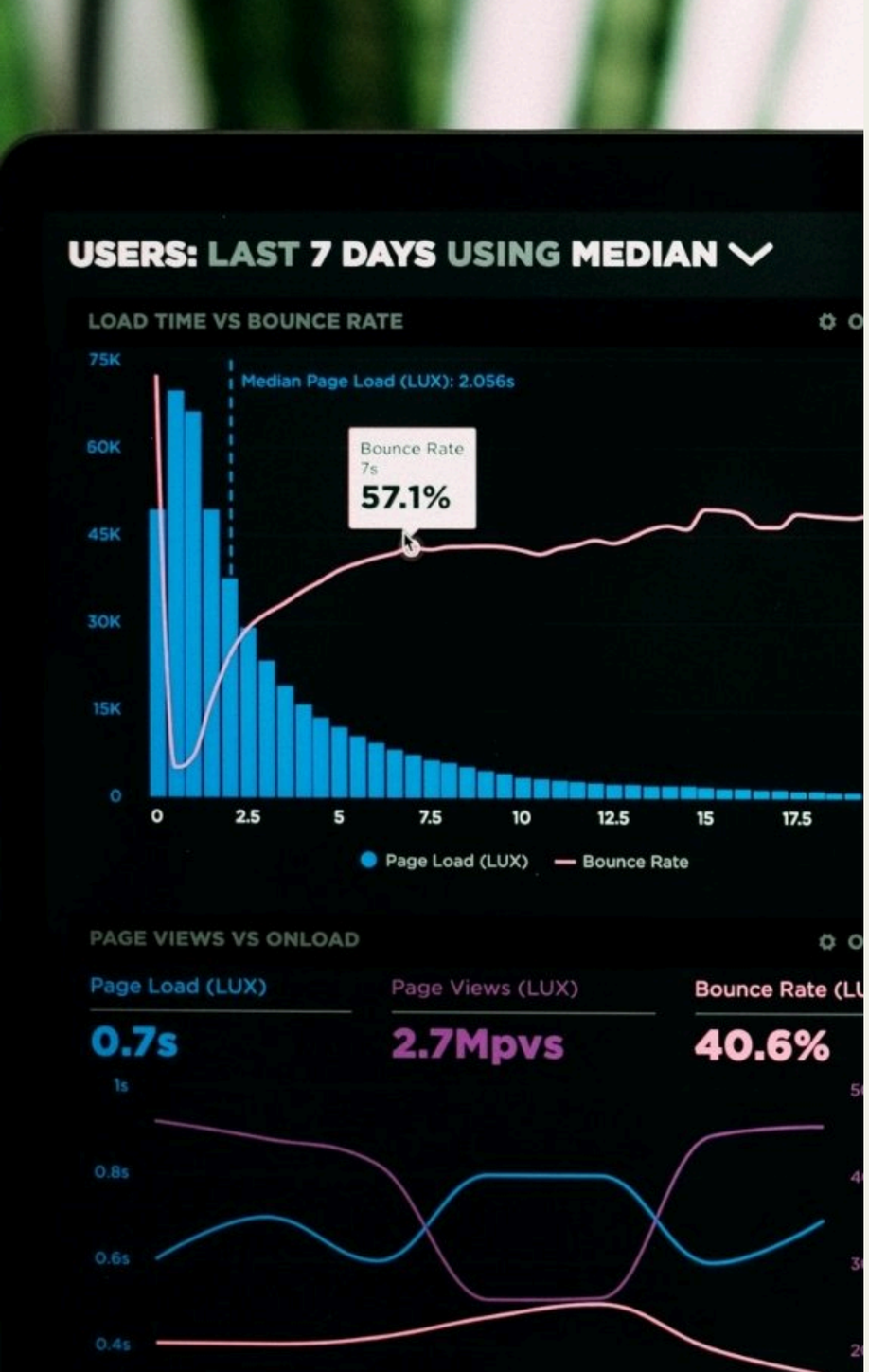
In a user-centric model, the risk of failure is reduced by constant validation against user needs.

### Identify problems

Traditional client-vendor models can lead to a disconnect between what's built and what's actually useful to the end user.

### Increase satisfaction

Focusing on the user experience increases customer satisfaction and long-term engagement.




# Measurable impact

All work has measures attached, so we know if we succeeded

### Results focused

Focusing on impact over output means we build things that truly add value.

### Quickly pivot

Measures let us change course quickly by showing whether our efforts are making a real difference.

### Measurable accountability

Data-driven insights improve stakeholder engagement, aligning expectations with real-world outcomes.



# Empowered teams

Teams guided by clear goals and accountable through measurable impact

### Take responsibility

Team ownership of problems leads to more effective, tailored solutions.

### True solutions

Space for exploration lets teams focus on solutions that matter, not just delivery.

### Tradeoff decisions

Trusting teams to make decisions leads to better technical solutions and tradeoffs.



# Collaborative partners

Partnering on problems that span the real world and the digital one

### Shared process

A shared problem-solving process bridges technical and non-technical work, aligning us toward broader goals.

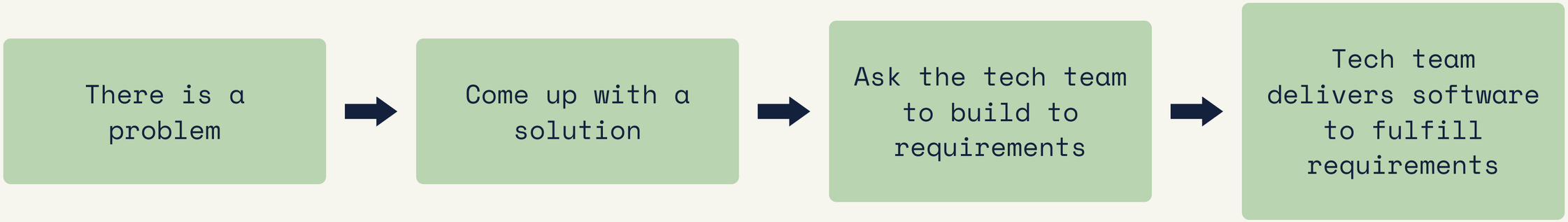
### Collaboration

Balancing ownership with collaboration is key when goals span tech and non-tech work and need investment from several groups.

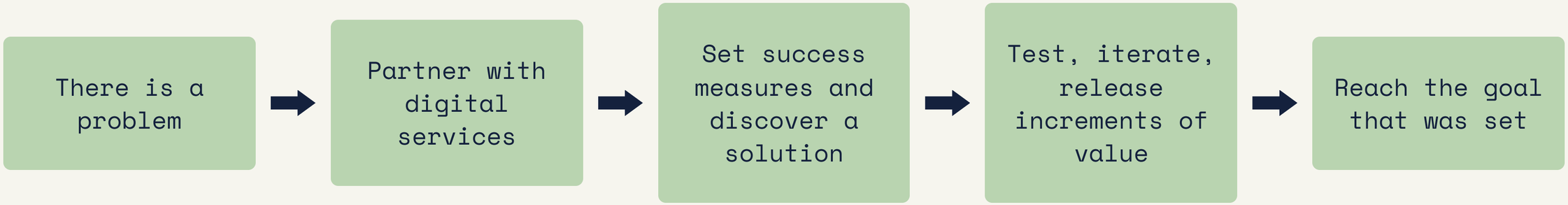
### One team

A shared belief in solving problems together builds one team focused on effective solutions.

# Traditional way of working



# New way of working



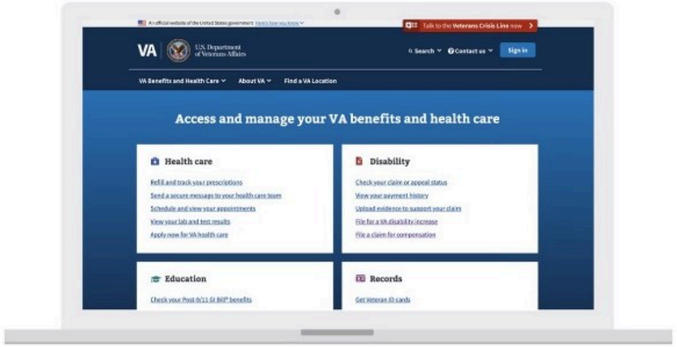
Example project:
VA website

## The Challenge

Each month, over 10 million people attempt to access the digital tools and content at the Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) and have historically struggled to find what they're looking for. Veterans experienced disjointed navigation between sites and pages, and found that the website was focused more on the structure of the agency than on their needs as Veterans. Digital modernization efforts needed to focus on improving the user experience.

## The Solution

The USDS team at VA and the Office of the Chief Technology Officer partnered with teams across VA to focus on quickly connecting users to the most commonly needed services and information VA offers. The result was the new VA.gov website, built with the input of over 5,000 Veterans, service members, caregivers, and family members.




## By the Numbers

**30%**

increase in the customer satisfaction score for the modernized pages, from an average of 53 to over 69

**1.7M**

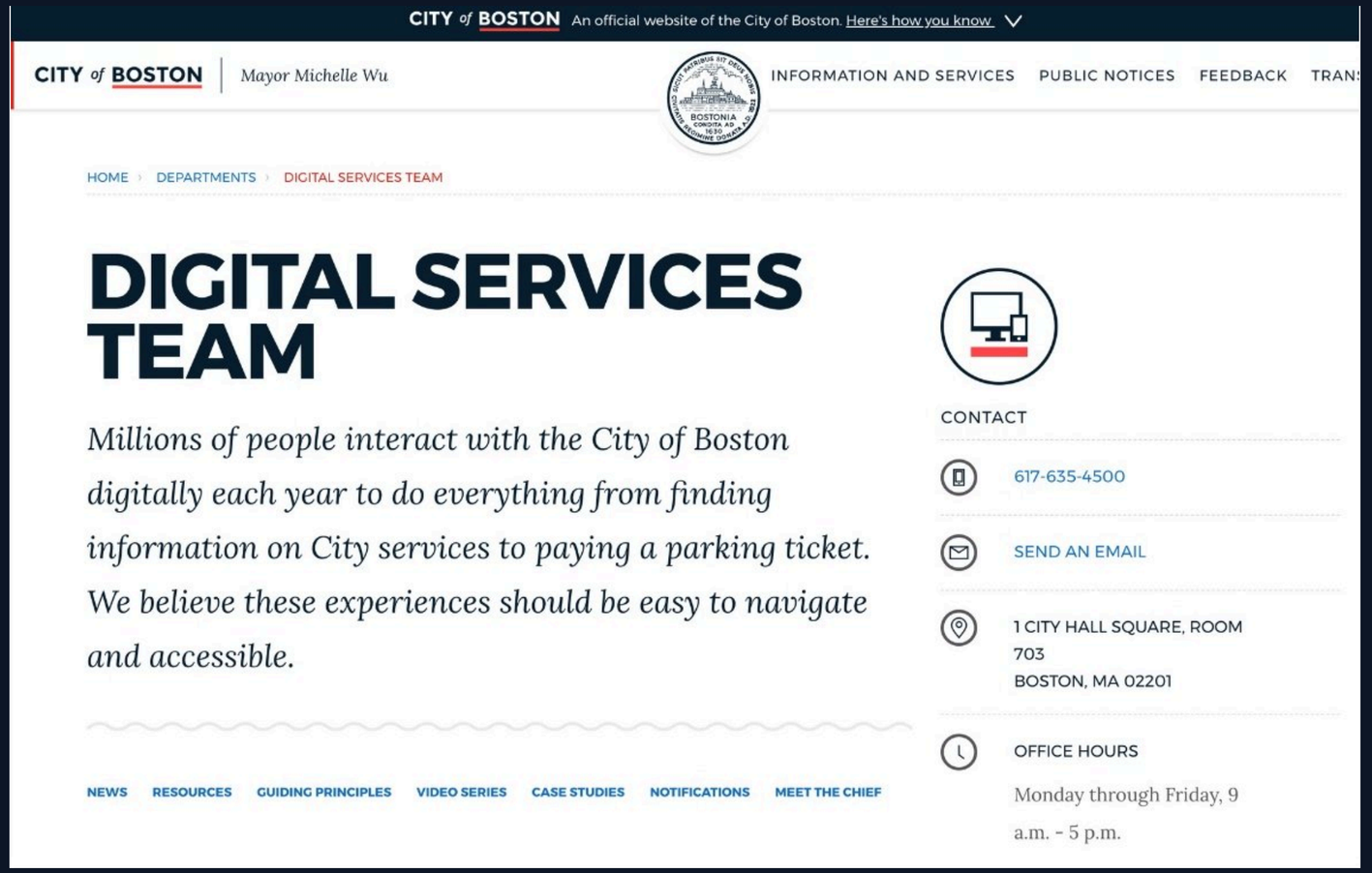
logins every month on VA.gov

View live project

UNITED STATES DIGITAL SERVICE

# This works

Happening in the federal government




# Not just the federal level, cities too!

Other cities: Philadelphia, Washington D.C., Chicago, Baltimore


Digital Services
Process
Breakdown
IDEATE
TEST
DEFINE
PROTOTYPE
Problem
DEFINE
IDEATE

# Who you'll work with

### Product manager

New

Owns the roadmap and the order of the work. The person to ask "what" and "why."

### Product owner

Runs weekly request triage, owns the small request board, writes stories and accepts finished work.

### UX designer and researcher

Elevated

Talks to the people who use the service and tests ideas with them before anything is built.

### Development team

Builds in short, focused iterations, delivering value in increments so the problem actually gets solved.

### Content strategist

Brings your requests to triage, leads training and guides, and supports champions.

### You: partners and champions

Bring the problem, join the process, own the non-technical parts, and help your colleagues succeed.

# The process

Eight steps in four stages. It runs as a loop, not a line.

| Define | Discover | Deliver | Enable |
| --- | --- | --- | --- |
| 1. Capture ideas | 4. Discover: research, choose, test | 5. Slice the work | 8. Enable: launch, train, measure, feed back |
| 2. Set direction | | 6. Build and release | |
| 3. Plan the quarter | | 7. Review the sprint | |

The process

# Define: steps 1 to 3

PRODUCT MANAGER (lead)



**1. Capture ideas.** Every request gets an answer within five business days.

**2. Set direction.** Each year, vision, strategy and up to three goals, with leadership.

**3. Plan the quarter.** A Now, Next, Later roadmap and commitments the team believes it can keep.

**Your part:** bring us problems, not only solutions. Join the advisory group if asked. The roadmap is open to you any time.

The process

# Discover: step 4

UX DESIGNER AND RESEARCHER (lead)



**Research.** Understand users and their "as is" process, your stakeholders, the landscape, the technology and the rules.

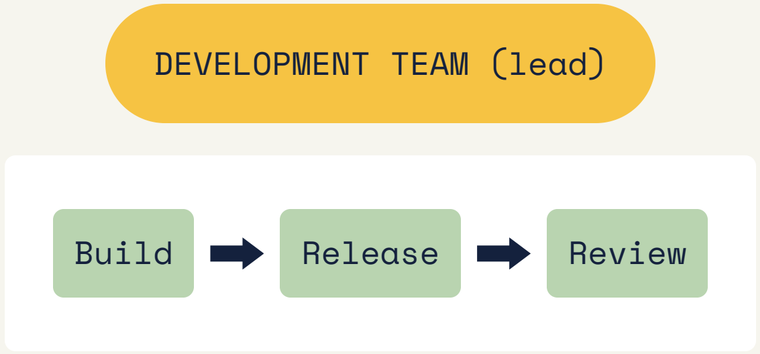
**Choose.** Name the real problem and line up at least three ways to solve it.

**Test.** Try the riskiest idea as cheaply as possible, then decide: build it, don't build it, or try something different.

**Your part:** connect us to the people who use the service, share what you know, and be open to "we shouldn't build this."

The process

# Deliver: steps 5 to 7




**Regularly deliver small increments of value.** Each slice works for someone on its own.

**Learn early, make changes along the way.**

**Communicate often.** A demo and a sprint report every two weeks.

**Your part:** come to the demos, tell us what you see, and say early if something doesn't fit how your staff work.

The process

# Enable: step 8

CONTENT STRATEGIST and WHOLE TEAM



**The people we work with stay part of the process** and can keep going after the team moves on.

**Every user can succeed with the service,** not just reach it: guides, training, champions and support.

**We measure the outcome and listen.** Feedback goes back into triage and starts the loop again.

**Your part:** name a champion, release staff time for training, and tell us what isn't working.

# How to work with us

Bringing us a request, and what you'll hear and when

# Every request gets an answer

Submit through the intake form or your content strategist. We review weekly and answer within five business days.

| Outcome | What it means | What you'll hear |
|---|---|---|
| **Already on the roadmap** | It's already planned | A link so you can follow progress |
| **Small request** | A bounded change to something that exists, under one sprint | When we expect to get to it, and when it's done |
| **Large or strategic** | New, bigger than a sprint, or could move a goal | It's in our idea log; we review it each quarter |
| **Idea for improvement** | Would help people beyond you | We'll look closer when we plan next quarter |
| **Will not do** | Not feasible, too costly, or off strategy | No, with the reason, and an alternative if there is one |
| **Future consideration** | Worth keeping, but it doesn't fit now | Not yes, not no, and we won't follow up |

# Bigger asks start with a conversation

Before a large request goes in the idea log, the product manager meets you to work through five questions.

### 1. What's the problem?

What happens today, who it affects, what goes wrong. Not yet the solution.

### 2. Is there a hard deadline?

A law, policy or funding date, or a wish? Mandates are treated as required work.

### 3. Do we need discovery?

If the problem is real but unclear, research comes before any decision.

### 4. Can the scope shrink?

A smaller version may solve most of it and fit as a small request now.

### 5. How do we work?

What can happen this quarter, what waits for planning, and when you'll hear.

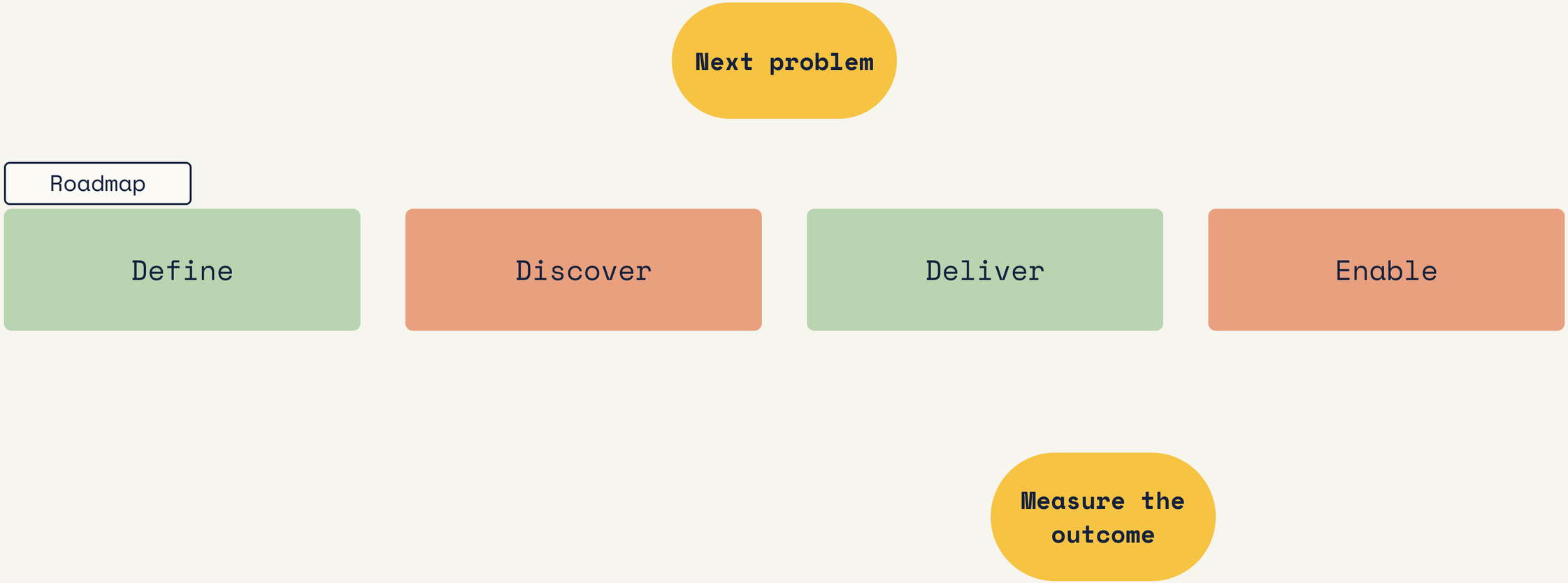
### You leave knowing

What happens next and when you'll hear from us.

# What you'll hear, and when

| When | What |
| --- | --- |
| **Any time** | The roadmap is open: goals, what's in progress, what's next |
| **Weekly** | An answer on every request submitted that week |
| **Every 2 weeks** | A sprint demo you're invited to, and a sprint report on every commitment |
| **Monthly** | Advisory group: partners and community voices check the work still fits |
| **Quarterly** | A new plan for the quarter and an updated roadmap |
| **When it ships** | Release notes written for the people whose work changes |

# Repeat with the next problem



# This is a conversation starter

We are always listening and ready to collaborate, to make sure we're delivering value to the community and to employees.

[your team's email or intake link]

